

A NATURALIST'S GUIDE TO COMING HOME

+

The Katy & Fulshear

lifestyle collection



+

CURATED BY

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BROKER · ASSOCIATE · RE/MAX CINCO RANCH

GROWN · GUIDED · GATHERED

DIGITAL EDITION



*“The land knows you,
even when you are lost.”*

— Robin Wall Kimmerer



FOR THE FAMILIES

*who choose this corner of Texas —
may your roots take quickly,
and your shade trees grow tall.*

Contents

A field guide to your new chapter.



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Each chapter opens with a botanical mark. Look for the small maroon leaf tucked here and there — a quiet nod to where Christa studied.

I

CHAPTER
An invitation.

Welcome

Howdy, & come on in.

A greeting borrowed from a place that taught Christa how to plant things that last. Used here on purpose — it is the truest hello in Texas.

Choosing a home is more than a financial transaction — it is choosing the soil your family will grow in. The Katy and Fulshear corridor west of Houston offers a rare pairing: small-town texture, big-city access, and a landscape that rewards anyone who pays attention to it. Wide-canopied live oaks. Bluebonnets that arrive on cue every March. Migratory painted buntings that pass through in May. A network of trails that lets you walk to coffee, to a farmers market, or to a neighbor's porch.

This guide is part relocation reference, part field journal. On the surface it answers the questions every newcomer asks — which neighborhood, which schools, which highway. Underneath, it is meant to be kept: a year-round companion for the family who wants to truly live here, not just live at an address.

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

Read it once cover-to-cover before your move — then keep it on the kitchen shelf. The Year in Bloom calendar (Chapter IX) and the Tree Canopy guide (Chapter X) are written for the family who is still here in five, ten, twenty years.

“Where you live is the first chapter of who your children will become. Choose the page carefully.

— Christa



II

CHAPTER
Twenty-three years.

Meet Christa

Your advocate, rooted here.

Twenty-three years guiding families home — with the patience of someone who knows things take a season to take hold.

Christa Burgess is not, strictly speaking, a salesperson. She is a horticulturist who happens to negotiate real estate contracts — a distinction her clients notice within the first showing. Where another agent points out granite countertops, Christa is already noting the sun exposure on the back patio, the drainage in the side yard, and whether the live oak in the front has the kind of branch architecture that means it will still be there in fifty years.

She studied at Texas A&M University, where the horticulture program planted a habit she has never quite shaken: she walks every property like a botanist before she walks it like a broker. Soil first. Foundation second. Her training at the Disney Institute brought a second discipline — the choreography of service. The combination is unusual: the patience of a gardener, the precision of a theme-park operator, and the negotiating instincts of someone who has closed transactions in this market for over two decades. The result is what her clients have taken to calling “white-glove relocation.”

FAST FACTS

23+	Years guiding families to and from this market	Local	Mother, neighbor, longtime resident
A&M	Texas A&M alumna — horticulture roots	RE/MAX	Broker-Associate, RE/MAX Cinco Ranch
Disney	Disney Institute trained in service design	HAR	Active member, Houston Association of Realtors

+ A NOTE FROM CHRISTA

I tell every new client the same thing: a house is a thirty-year decision wrapped in a thirty-day deadline. My job is to slow that down for you — to make sure the soil, the school zone, and the seller’s disclosure all get the same careful look.

A Different Kind of Showing

What it actually feels like to work with Christa.

Most relocation agents hand you a stack of MLS sheets and a list of school ratings. Christa hands you a notebook. The notebook fills up over the first weekend of showings: commute trials at rush hour, soil quality in the back beds, the specific cul-de-sac children, the HOA's tolerance for vegetable gardens in the front yard, and whether the mature pecan you fell in love with has root rot.

Her clients return to her not because she sold them a house but because she helped them choose a place. There is a difference, and it shows up in year five — when their crepe myrtles bloom on schedule and the kids walk to the same elementary they would have driven to anywhere else.

“Christa identified two foundation issues our inspector missed and walked our negotiation like she was moving in herself. Six years later, her house-warming bluebonnet seeds are still coming up in our front bed.

— The Patel Family, Cross Creek Ranch

“We interviewed four agents. Christa was the only one who asked what we wanted to grow, not just what we wanted to buy. That told us everything.

— The Millers, Fulshear

There is an old Texas A&M idea that the team on the field plays better when the people in the stands are with them. Christa believes the same is true of relocation. Her job, the way she sees it, is to be the twelfth player on the family's team — ready to step in wherever the gap shows up, whether that's a school transfer letter at 10 p.m. or a soil sample at the curb on a Saturday.

III

CHAPTER

Two neighbors, one watershed.

The Lay of the Land

Katy & Fulshear at a glance.

Two neighbors, one watershed, very different personalities. Knowing the difference is the first step toward choosing where you belong.

West of the Houston Beltway, the prairie that once fed bison now feeds school districts, Friday-night lights, and one of the fastest-growing residential corridors in the country. Two communities anchor the area: Katy, the established core, and Fulshear, the open frontier just to its west.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — WHY “KATY?”

Long before it was a master-planned suburb, Katy was a railroad town called Cane Island — named for the wild stands of sugar cane that grew along Buffalo Bayou’s tributary. The town took its modern name from the Missouri–Kansas–Texas Railroad, the M-K-T, which everyone simply called “the Katy.” The depot is gone, but the rail line still runs through the heart of town — and so does the name.

A QUICK COMPASS

	KATY	FULSHEAR
<i>Feel</i>	Established suburb	Hill-country meets prairie
<i>Lot Size</i>	Quarter to half acre	Half acre to several acres
<i>Build Year</i>	1990s–2010s	2010s–today
<i>School District</i>	Katy ISD	Lamar CISD & Katy ISD
<i>Tree Canopy</i>	Mature live oak	Younger — plantable
<i>Commute</i>	I-10 / Westpark	FM 1093 / Westpark
<i>Best For</i>	Move-in-ready families	Custom builders, growers

A Word on the Watershed

Both communities sit within the Brazos and Buffalo Bayou watersheds, which is why drainage — not square footage — is often the most important factor in selecting a lot. After Hurricane Harvey, builders adapted with elevated pads, deeper detention basins, and more permeable hardscape. Christa walks every backyard with this in mind. She will show you the elevation map for any property before she shows you the kitchen.

Fulshear: The New Frontier

An open landscape, an honest tradeoff.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — OF THE OLD THREE HUNDRED

Fulshear traces its name to Churchill Fulshear, one of Stephen F. Austin's "Old Three Hundred" — the founding families granted land in 1824 along the Brazos River as part of the first authorized Anglo settlement of Texas. The Fulshear headright, a league of fertile river-bottom prairie, became the family ranch and, eventually, the town. When you cross FM 1093 westbound, you are crossing onto land that has been continuously farmed and ranched for two hundred years.

Fulshear was, until recently, a quiet ranching town — one stoplight, two feed stores, a population that fit on the water-tower roster. The corridor opened, and now Fulshear is arguably the most-watched zip code in greater Houston. The tradeoff is honest: more land, fewer mature trees. But for a gardener — or for anyone who wants to plant the shade their grandchildren will sit in — it is an invitation, not a deficit.

+ NATURALIST'S NOTE

The whole region sits in USDA Hardiness Zone 9a (winter lows 20–25°F). That single number is what makes citrus, figs, satsumas, pomegranates, and tropical hibiscus reasonable backyard choices. Keep it on a sticky note on your fridge — every gardening label in America is organized around it.

“We wanted a modern home but with the peace of the countryside. Fulshear gave us exactly that. Christa helped us find a lot that will never have neighbors behind it.

— The Miller Family

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

When buying acreage in Fulshear, always confirm two things before falling in love: the MUD district (some are still under heavy development bond payoff) and whether the lot has a deed-restricted view easement to the green space behind it. The view you fell for can be replaced by a tree line in eighteen months without one.

IV

CHAPTER
A working preserve.

Cross Creek Ranch

Where trails begin.

3,200 acres organized around the principle that a child should be able to walk to a creek.

Cross Creek Ranch is the corridor's working preserve. Built around the watershed of Flewellen Creek, the master plan reserves more than half its acreage as green space. The result is a community where trails are not amenities — they are the spine.

PREMIER AMENITIES

Adventure Island Water Park

Resort-style pools, slides, and splash pads.

Flewellen Creek Park

Native-prairie restoration with interpretive signage.

The Links at Cross Creek

A nine-hole course threading through preserved wetland.

Trail System

40+ miles of paved and natural-surface paths along the creek.

Activity Center

Group fitness, lap pool, full-time activities director.

+ NATURALIST'S NOTE

The Flewellen Creek prairie restoration is one of the rare master-planned community projects to actively re-establish native bluestem, Indian grass, and switchgrass. Visit in late October — the seedheads catch the low light and turn the whole bottomland the color of a copper penny.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — BRAZOS DE DIOS

The Brazos River, which Cross Creek's western trails eventually empty toward, was named by sixteenth-century Spanish explorers "Los Brazos de Dios" — the Arms of God — reportedly after a desperate party found drinking water on its banks. It is the longest river contained entirely within Texas, and the bottomland it has built over millennia is what gives Fulshear its uncommon tree diversity and Cross Creek its uncommonly photogenic afternoon light.

Why Buyers Choose Cross Creek

A pattern Christa has watched develop.

Three buyer profiles dominate Cross Creek: the relocating energy executive who wants newer construction without sacrificing trees, the second-time buyer trading up from inside Beltway 8, and the family with school-aged children who would rather walk than drive. The community accommodates all three, but the third is who the master plan was really built for.

Resale Pattern

Days-on-market in Cross Creek typically run shorter than the surrounding zip-code average, especially for homes that back to green space rather than another fence line. Christa tracks these comps weekly and can show you the true premium of a green-space lot before you write an offer.

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

Ask about the lot's relationship to the trail. There is a meaningful difference between backing to the trail (privacy concerns, slightly lower price) and siding to the trail (the sweet spot — access without exposure). I have seen this single distinction change resale by 4–6%.

Looking Ahead

Phase development will continue through the late 2020s, with the western residential sections feathering toward Fulshear proper. Buyers whose top priority is mature canopy should focus on the eastern villages; buyers whose top priority is custom flexibility should look west.





CHAPTER

An established garden.

Cinco Ranch

Eleven pools. Seventeen courts. A canopy old enough to remember the prairie.

Cinco Ranch is the master-planned community that other master-planned communities study.

Begun in 1991, Cinco Ranch has had time to do what new developments cannot: grow. The live oaks along the boulevards now form true canopies. The crepe myrtles have reached their adult height. The original families who moved in for elementary-school zoning are staying for grandchildren.

The Villages of Cinco

South Lake

The original gated enclave. Lakefront lots, mature canopy, high resale stability. Best for buyers who value establishment over newness.

Greenway Village

Closer to LaCenterra and the elementary feeder — a walkable corner of the community that buyers underestimate.

Equestrian

Larger lots, country club proximity, the area's most consistent appreciation curve.

West / North Lake

Newer construction, modern floor plans, lake amenities. A strong choice for first-time Cinco buyers.

AMENITIES AT A GLANCE

11 community pools · 17 tennis courts · The Beach Club at Cinco Ranch · The Golf Club at Cinco Ranch · LaCenterra town center (dining, boutique retail, the Central Green concert lawn) · Cinco Ranch Branch Library · miles of connected trails linking villages, schools, and parks.



NATURALIST'S NOTE

The signature live oaks (Quercus virginiana) along Cinco Ranch Boulevard are now thirty-plus years old. A mature live oak drops its leaves only briefly in early spring — don't panic in February. They are not dying; they are about to push new growth and a season of pollen. Texas A&M's most beloved tree, the Century Tree on the College Station campus, is a live oak too.



Living the Cinco Day

A morning, an afternoon, an evening.

MORNING

School drop-off at one of the seven on-site Katy ISD campuses, then a coffee at LaCenterra. The bayou trail is busiest between 6:30 and 8:00 a.m. — plan around it, or join it.

AFTERNOON

Pool season runs late April through October. Library story time on Tuesdays. The Golf Club's short course is forgiving enough for beginners and beautiful enough for visitors.

EVENING

Concerts on the Central Green most Friday nights, March through November. Dinner along the LaCenterra promenade. Kids on bikes until the streetlights come on — still a thing here.

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

Cinco's HOA is among the most active in Texas. Read the covenants before you bring home a vegetable bed plan — several villages allow raised beds in the back only. I keep current copies on file and will walk you through them page by page.

Curiosity, in this market, pays dividends. If a property has a live oak older than the subdivision itself, it was likely a fence-line tree on the original ranch — the kind of tree the early Cinco surveyors purposely built around. Walk underneath it before you sign anything.

VI

CHAPTER

Quietly excellent.

Firethorne & Grand Lakes

Two communities that punch above their marketing weight.

Firethorne

Firethorne is for the buyer who wants a large modern home, a competitive neighborhood swim team, and HOA dues that don't resemble a country club bill. Built around three lakes and a contemporary clubhouse, the community has a noticeably tight social fabric — ask about the Fourth of July parade and the autumn farmers market on the green.

Best for: families who want amenity-rich living without the price premium of the most-marketed addresses; buyers prioritizing newer construction and energy efficiency.

Grand Lakes

Grand Lakes was master-planned around a “four corner park” concept — every home is a short walk from a green space, lake, or playground. The result is the kind of walkable density usually associated with much older neighborhoods. The aesthetic is classic, the streets are tree-lined, and the resale market is famously stable.

Best for: buyers who value walkability as a lifestyle, not a buzzword; families with multiple young children who will use the four parks across four corners.



NATURALIST'S NOTE

Firethorne (Pyracantha) is itself a wonderful Texas-tough shrub — evergreen, drought-resistant, with brilliant orange-red berries that feed cedar waxwings every January. Plant it where you can see it from a kitchen window, and you'll have a winter's worth of bird traffic.



CHRISTA'S TIP

When comparing Firethorne or Grand Lakes against Cinco or Cross Creek, run the math on monthly carry costs — not just price. Both compete more aggressively on dues and MUD tax exposure than buyers expect. I will build you a side-by-side spreadsheet for any four homes you tour.





PART II

The Living

A field reference for the family who stays.



VII

CHAPTER
A field reference.

The Naturalist's Notebook

Plants that will not let you down here.

The next four chapters are the part of this guide we hope you keep on the kitchen shelf.

The single biggest mistake we see new arrivals make is gardening on East-Coast or Midwest instinct. Houston's climate plays by different rules: our growing season runs backwards in summer (heat shuts everything down), our best planting windows are October and February, and our native plants are tougher — if you let them be native.

What follows is a working horticulturist's shorthand: the plants that will absolutely thrive, a month-by-month calendar, and a tree guide tied to the specific neighborhoods in this collection.

FIVE PLANTS THAT CANNOT FAIL HERE

- ✦ **Texas Lantana** — Drought-proof, butterfly magnet, blooms April through frost.
- ✦ **Esperanza / Yellow Bells** — A shrub that becomes a small tree. Yellow trumpet blooms in 100°F heat.
- ✦ **Pride of Barbados** — Tropical fire-orange spires; freezes back, returns harder.
- ✦ **Mystic Spires Salvia** — A Texas Superstar release. Hummingbirds in residence by May.
- ✦ **Knock Out Roses** — The set-it-and-forget-it landscape rose. Three flushes a year, minimal disease pressure.

✦ NATURALIST'S NOTE

The "Texas Superstar" program is run jointly by Texas A&M AgriLife Extension and the state's horticulture research stations. When you see the trademark on a plant tag at your local nursery, it has been tested in this climate. It is the single most useful label in any Texas garden center.

VIII

CHAPTER

Twelve months in Zone 9a.

A Year in Bloom

The gardener's calendar.

- JAN** Plant trees & shrubs (root growth in cool soil). Prune dormant fruit trees. Plant onions and shallots.
- FEB** Average last frost: mid-month. Start tomato seeds indoors. Last call to plant fruit trees.
- MAR** BLUEBONNETS PEAK. Sow warm-season vegetables. Plant caladium bulbs. Mulch every bed.
- APR** Indian paintbrush takes over from bluebonnets. Tomatoes set fruit. Plant tropicals (hibiscus, plumeria).
- MAY** Painted buntings pass through — watch the feeders. Plant okra and southern peas. Deadhead roses.
- JUN** Heat establishes. Switch irrigation to deep, infrequent. Pinch basil weekly. Last lawn fertilization.
- JUL** Garden survival mode. Crepe myrtles in full bloom. Resist the urge to “crepe murder” — prune lightly.
- AUG** Plan the fall garden. Start fall tomato starts (yes, you get a second crop). Order spring bulbs.
- SEP** Cool-season seeds: lettuce, spinach, kale, broccoli. Divide overgrown perennials.
- OCT** Fall color begins. Plant pansies, snapdragons, dianthus. Native grasses peak. Plant new trees.
- NOV** Average first frost: late month. Plant spring bulbs (daffodil, narcissus). Cover citrus on freeze nights.
- DEC** Holly berries peak — cardinals everywhere. Bring tropicals in on freeze nights. Rest.

◆ **CHRISTA'S TIP**

New arrivals from the north routinely fertilize their lawns in spring like they did up there. Don't. In Zone 9a, St. Augustine grass wants its big feeding in October, with a light spring touch-up. Save the bag and the water.



A Word on the Bluebonnet

Texas' state flower — and how to grow your own.

Lupinus texensis is the photograph that defines a Texas spring. It is also one of the most misunderstood plants in the state — chiefly because the timing is counter-intuitive. Bluebonnets are a winter annual: they germinate in fall, spend December through February as an unassuming green rosette, and bloom on cue between mid-March and mid-April.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — ADOPTED 1901

*The bluebonnet was named the state flower of Texas in 1901, after a spirited debate between supporters of the cotton boll, the prickly pear cactus, and the bluebonnet. The Colonial Dames of America carried the day. In 1971, the legislature — unwilling to choose between species — quietly amended the law to declare “any variety” of bluebonnet the official flower, sweeping in all six native *Lupinus* species. Texas: the only state where the state flower is technically a genus.*

HOW TO ESTABLISH A PATCH

- **Sow in October**

Scatter scarified seed onto bare, well-drained soil. They will not germinate in shade or in heavy clay.

- **Resist watering**

Once germinated, ignore them. Bluebonnets evolved on dry, rocky hillsides. Overwatering kills more patches than drought.

- **Don't mow until June**

Let the seedheads dry on the plant. Mowing in May erases next year's patch.

- **Add wine cups & paintbrush**

Companion natives extend the bloom window into May and create the photograph everyone is hoping for.

+ NATURALIST'S NOTE

Some clients receive a packet of bluebonnet seed in their closing gift basket. Plant them the first October you are in the house, and Christa promises a March photograph that will go on the front of your holiday card the following year.

IX

CHAPTER
Read the trees.

The Tree Canopy

Knowing your neighborhood by what grows in it.

Every community in this guide has a signature canopy. Read it.

A neighborhood's trees tell you when it was built, how the developer treated the original land, and what your summer electric bill is going to look like. Walk a property with the trees in mind, and you will see things the inspection report cannot capture.

CINCO RANCH*Live Oak · Crepe Myrtle · Drake Elm*

Mature 25–35 ft canopy on the original boulevards. Cooling effect on western elevations is real — measure your AC bill against a non-shaded comp.

CROSS CREEK*Bald Cypress · Bur Oak · Mexican Sycamore*

Younger but planted intentionally. The cypress along the creek system are some of the most photogenic in the area in late October.

FULSHEAR*Pecan · Live Oak · Cedar Elm*

Heritage trees on remnant ranchland — the most variable inventory of any community in this guide. Always pay for the certified arborist report.

FIRETHORNE*Chinese Pistache · Live Oak · Loblolly Pine*

A working mix — the Chinese pistache delivers the area's best fall color (gold to red) reliably each November.

GRAND LAKES*Magnolia · Live Oak · Crepe Myrtle*

The classic Texas suburban canopy, fully matured. Magnolia pollen in March is real; budget accordingly.

The Live Oak: A Closer Look

An inheritance, not a landscaping choice.

The live oak (*Quercus virginiana*) is, hands down, the signature tree of greater Houston — and arguably the most generous tree in the South. A single mature specimen can drop summer ground temperatures beneath it by 10–15°F. If you have one in your front yard, you have inherited a living air conditioner.

Treat it accordingly: no construction inside the drip line, ever. No raised flowerbeds tucked against the trunk. No sprinkler heads spraying the bark. The tree pre-dated your subdivision, your house, and likely your great-grandparents — and with care will outlast all three.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — THE CENTURY TREE

On the campus of Texas A&M University in College Station stands a live oak planted in 1890 from an acorn carried in a student's pocket. Now called the Century Tree, its canopy spans nearly the width of a football field. Aggie tradition holds that couples who walk hand-in-hand beneath it will marry; couples who walk through alone, will not. Whatever you make of the superstition, it is a useful reminder: a live oak is a multigenerational object. Plant one for the family who will live in your house after you do.

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

If a property has a live oak older than the subdivision itself, request a certified arborist report before you write your offer. I keep a short list of three local arborists who give an honest read — not just the inspection-report-friendly version. An ailing 80-year-old live oak removal can cost more than a kitchen renovation.





CHAPTER

On the Central Flyway.

Wings & Wildflowers

A short field guide to the wildlife your new yard will host.

You are moving onto the eastern edge of the Central Flyway — one of the four great migratory corridors of North America. Roughly half of all bird species on the continent either live here or pass through. A backyard feeder, a small water source, and any flowering shrub will turn your kitchen window into theater.

BACKYARD BIRDS YOU'LL GET TO KNOW

- ✦ **Northern Cardinal** — Year-round. Loud, bright, territorial — the patriarch of any feeder.
- ✦ **Carolina Wren** — Tiny, talkative, will nest inside your garage if you leave the door cracked.
- ✦ **Painted Bunting** — The trophy. April–May migrant. Looks like a tropical fish in feather form.
- ✦ **Eastern Bluebird** — Increasingly common in Fulshear. Put up a nesting box and they will move in.
- ✦ **Belted Kingfisher** — Christa's namesake bird. Watch for them along the creek banks at Cross Creek and Flewellen — a rattling call and a hovering dive.
- ✦ **Roseate Spoonbill** — Visit the Brazos Bend State Park rookery — 30 minutes south, worth a Saturday.

A POLLINATOR GARDEN IN 6 PLANTS

Lantana (butterflies) · Mealy Blue Sage (bees) · Coral Honeysuckle (hummingbirds) · Gregg's Mistflower (queen butterflies in October) · Zinnia (everything) · Frogfruit (a native ground cover that hosts three butterfly species).



NATURALIST'S NOTE

The most reliable hummingbird food in this climate is not the sugar feeder — it is a tubular red flower. Plant one Turk's Cap or one coral honeysuckle and you will host more birds than the feeder ever delivered, with no mold and no boiling water.



XI

CHAPTER

The heartbeat.

Education & Excellence

Two top-rated districts, one shared expectation: kids graduate ready.

Education is the heartbeat of this region — and, frankly, half the reason it has grown the way it has. Two districts dominate: Katy ISD (Cinco Ranch, Firethorne, Grand Lakes, Cross Creek’s eastern half) and Lamar Consolidated ISD (Fulshear and Cross Creek’s western half). Both consistently rank among the top public districts in Texas.

What sets the districts apart

Katy ISD is best known for breadth: nine high schools, a robust gifted-and-talented program, the Miller Career and Technology Center, and athletic programs that have produced state titles in nearly every UIL classification. Lamar CISD is the faster-growing of the two and has invested heavily in newer campus construction. Fulshear High School (opened 2018) is among the most modern public campuses in the state.

◆ CHRISTA'S TIP

Never trust a listing’s school assignment without verifying with the district’s zoning office. Boundary lines re-draw every few years as new schools open. I provide a current zoning verification on every property we tour, with the elementary, middle, and high school walking-route maps included.

Beyond public schools

The area also hosts strong private and faith-based options — The Village School, British International School of Houston, Pope John XXIII, Fort Bend Christian Academy, and the Awty International School (slightly closer to downtown). For a family relocating with international school requirements, Christa keeps current waitlist data on each.

★ A TEXAS NOTE — A LAND-GRANT TRADITION

The depth of Texas’ public education system has roots in the Texas Constitution of 1876, which set aside one million acres of public land to fund the establishment of the state’s first land-grant universities. Texas A&M University (chartered 1876, opened 1876) and the University of Texas (1883) emerged from that endowment. The same civic appetite for serious schools shows up in this corridor today — it is, in a sense, the same impulse, two centuries on.

XII

CHAPTER

Three highways, two airports.

Commuting & Connectivity

Getting anywhere from here.

Location, in this case, really is everything. Katy and Fulshear sit at the intersection of Interstate 10 (the Energy Corridor and downtown), the Westpark Tollway (Galleria, Uptown, Texas Medical Center), and Grand Parkway / Highway 99 (everywhere else). For a professional whose office is anywhere on the western half of metro Houston, this is the easiest commute in the metro.

TYPICAL DRIVE TIMES

The Energy Corridor (BP, Shell, ConocoPhillips)	15–25 min
Galleria & Uptown	25–40 min
Downtown Houston	35–55 min
Texas Medical Center	45–60 min
George Bush Intercontinental (IAH)	45–65 min
William P. Hobby (HOU)	50–70 min
Brazos Bend State Park	30–40 min
Galveston Beaches	70–85 min

◆ **CHRISTA'S TIP**

Always do your commute trial twice: 7:30 a.m. on a Tuesday, and 5:30 p.m. on a Thursday. Those are the worst-case numbers. If they pass, you will love every other commute. I will arrange showings around them.

★ **A TEXAS NOTE — SPINDLETOP, INDIRECTLY**

The reason there is an “Energy Corridor” ten minutes from Katy is, in a roundabout way, a single oil gusher near Beaumont in 1901. Spindletop made Texas synonymous with petroleum and seeded the corporate offices that, three generations later, anchor I-10 west of the Beltway. Half of the houses you will tour in this corridor were built for engineers whose grandparents worked rigs.

XIII

CHAPTER
Curated.

Christa's Local Favorites

Sorted not by rating, but by why she loves them.

FOR COFFEE & A THINK

- ✦ **Humble Grounds Coffeehouse** (*Fulshear & Old Katy*)
Locally roasted beans (Mr. HG roasts in-house) and the breakfast tacos that took home Best of Katy in 2025. Two locations — Avenue C in old downtown Katy, and Fry Road in Fulshear — each one a true front-porch coffee shop.
- ✦ **Essence House Café** (*Fulshear*)
Has been Fulshear's hometown breakfast since the population was under a thousand. Family-run, full breakfast served all day. The pancakes are the order; the regulars are the bonus.
- ✦ **Texana Café** (*Fulshear*)
A working café with a rare mission — staffed by neurodiverse adults gaining real-world job experience under board-certified support. The food earns the visit on its own; the soup-of-the-day brings you back.

FOR DINNER

- ✦ **Pearl & Vine** (*Katy / Nelson Way*)
Independently owned, Wine Spectator's 2025 Award of Excellence, voted Best Date Night and Best Happy Hour in the Best of Katy/Fort Bend Foodies awards. Wood-fired steaks, a serious oyster bar. The patio overlooks a small lake — ask for a table on it.
- ✦ **Local Table** (*LaCenterra at Cinco Ranch*)
The Eskandari family ran Hungry's Café inside the Loop for thirty-five years before opening Local Table for their grandchildren's neighborhood. The comfort food of a Houston institution, served on the right side of the Grand Parkway.
- ✦ **Dozier's BBQ & Meat Market** (*Downtown Fulshear*)
Founded 1957 by Ed Dozier — the man who won the very first Houston Livestock & Rodeo BBQ Cook-Off and shipped bacon to the White House for President George H. W. Bush. Closed in 2024; reopened 2025 by Ed's great-grandson, working the original recipes.
- ✦ **Phat Eatery** (*Katy Asian Town*)
James Beard Award Semifinalist (the late Alex Au-Yeung, 2022); Houston Chronicle Top 100. Order the beef rendang, the roti canai, and the sizzling tofu — and bring more people than you think you need.

FOR GROCERIES & GROWING

- ✦ **H-E-B Plus!** (*Cinco Ranch*)
Texan grocery royalty. Flagship rivals a Whole Foods on produce; the in-house bakery is dangerous.
- ✦ **Enchanted Forest Garden Center** (*Richmond*)
Christa's favorite nursery. Knowledgeable staff, deep native-plant inventory.
- ✦ **Nelson Water Gardens** (*Katy*)
For the buyer with a backyard pond ambition. Disappearing fountains are their specialty.
- ✦ **Saturday Farmers Market** (*Fulshear City Hall*)
Year-round. Local honey, true tomatoes, and breakfast tacos from a tent that's been there a decade.

For the Kids — and the Grown-Ups

Where Christa goes outside.

- ✦ **Mary Jo Peckham Park**
Ducks, fishing pond, indoor pool. The first park to visit on the first weekend.
- ✦ **Typhoon Texas Waterpark**
Local-owned, half the line of the chain parks. Open Memorial Day through Labor Day.
- ✦ **Brazos Bend State Park**
Forty minutes south. Alligators in the wild. Astronomy nights at the on-site observatory — a rite of passage for any new Houston family.
- ✦ **George Bush Park**
7,800 acres on the western edge of Beltway 8 — the closest true wilderness to the metro. Trail running, equestrian paths, and a kite-flying hill that delivers in March.
- ✦ **Willow Fork Park**
Small, walkable, perfectly placed for a sunset stroll. The pavilion books up early for spring birthday parties.
- ✦ **Cross Creek Ranch Trails**
Open to the public for daytime walking. The Flewellen Creek segment is the prettiest 1.5-mile out-and-back in the corridor.
- ✦ **Katy Heritage Park**
A relocated historical village with restored prairie houses — free, quiet, and a worthwhile teaching afternoon for visiting grandparents.
- ✦ **Mercer Botanic Gardens**
An hour away in Humble. Worth it. Among the best free public gardens in the state.

✦ NATURALIST'S NOTE

Friday and Saturday mornings, between 7 and 9, are the best birding hours of the week in any of these parks. The air is cool, traffic on the trails is light, and migratory songbirds feed before the heat arrives.

XIV

CHAPTER
First 90 days.

The Settling-In Checklist

Your first three months — a keepsake worksheet.

Tear it out, check it off, breathe.

Below is the actual checklist Christa walks through with new clients. Most relocating families find that the second month is harder than the first — the cardboard is gone, but the rhythms are not yet built. This list helps.

WEEK ONE

- ☐ Update driver's license at TX DPS within 90 days
- ☐ Register vehicles with Fort Bend or Harris County
- ☐ Register to vote at the county office
- ☐ Set up trash & recycling pickup with your MUD
- ☐ Locate the closest urgent-care clinic
- ☐ Walk the property line — note any tree stress, irrigation issues, fence repairs

MONTH ONE

- ☐ Verify school zoning at the district office (don't rely on the listing sheet)
- ☐ Meet two neighbors on either side
- ☐ Find your coffee shop, your grocery store, and your pharmacy — in that order
- ☐ Identify the largest tree on your lot; have a certified arborist assess if older than 40 years
- ☐ Sign up for emergency alerts (FBC Alert / HC Ready)

MONTHS TWO & THREE

- ☐ Plant your first tree, even a small one — ownership starts in the soil
- ☐ Attend one community event (HOA meeting, farmers market, school open house)
- ☐ Identify your closest evacuation route (a Houston reality — don't skip this)
- ☐ Establish home preventative service rotations: HVAC twice a year, irrigation seasonally, pest quarterly
- ☐ Throw a small porch gathering — the neighborhood becomes home the day someone else's laughter is on it

Every Burgess client receives a small jute sack at closing: a packet of bluebonnet seed, a hand-written planting card, and the name of one tree she would plant in your front yard if it were hers. It is the smallest part of what we do together — and the part our clients tell us they remember most.

XV

CHAPTER

Verified at the time of printing.

Numbers to Know

The directory — emergency, civic, and the lines you'll actually call.

Tape this page to the inside of a kitchen cabinet.

Phone numbers move. Every entry below was confirmed against city, county, district, and utility websites the week this guide was printed. If a line is ever dead, the website is the second-best place to look — we've included those, too.

★ IN AN EMERGENCY

9-1-1

Police, fire, medical — from any phone. Cell calls auto-route to the nearest dispatch.

Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222 · Texas 211 (social services): dial 2-1-1

POLICE — NON-EMERGENCY

Katy Police Department	281-391-4848
<i>Serves City of Katy. cityofkaty.com/police</i>	
Fulshear Police Department	281-346-2202
<i>Serves City of Fulshear. fulsheartexas.gov/police</i>	
Fort Bend County Sheriff	281-341-4665
<i>Unincorporated FBC — Cross Creek, Firethorne, parts of Cinco. fbcsheriff.org</i>	
Harris County Sheriff	713-221-6000
<i>Unincorporated HC — northern Cinco Ranch & northwest Katy. harriscountyso.org</i>	

FIRE & EMS — NON-EMERGENCY

Willowfork Fire Dept. (FB ESD #2)	281-395-0011
<i>Cinco Ranch & southeast Katy. willowforkfire.com</i>	
Harris County ESD #48 Fire & EMS	281-599-8888
<i>North & west Katy in Harris County. hcesd48.org</i>	
Fulshear-Simonton Fire (FB ESD #4)	281-346-2800
<i>Fulshear, Cross Creek Ranch, Firethorne. fsfd.org</i>	

CITY HALLS

City of Katy	281-391-4800
<i>901 Avenue C, Katy 77493. cityofkaty.com</i>	
City of Fulshear	281-346-1796
<i>6611 W. Cross Creek Bend Ln., Fulshear 77441. fulsheartexas.gov</i>	

SCHOOL DISTRICTS

Katy ISD	281-396-6000
<i>Cinco Ranch, Firethorne, Grand Lakes, eastern Cross Creek. katyisd.org</i>	
Lamar Consolidated ISD	832-223-0000
<i>Fulshear, western Cross Creek Ranch. lcisd.org</i>	

Numbers to Know, continued

Utilities, government, and the kind of help you only need once — until the month you suddenly need it twice.

ELECTRICITY · CENTERPOINT TDU

- Power outage hotline **800-332-7143**
Or 713-207-2222. tracker.centerpointenergy.com
- Choose a retail provider
Texas is deregulated. Compare plans at powertochoose.org (state-run, free).

NATURAL GAS · CENTERPOINT

- Gas leak emergency **888-876-5786**
Leave the house first — then call. Then 911. Don't flip switches.
- Customer service / start service **800-752-8036**
centerpointenergy.com

WATER & SEWER

- City of Katy Utility Billing **281-391-4801**
In-city residents only. cityofkaty.com
- City of Fulshear Utility Billing **281-346-8830**
In-city residents only. fulsheartexas.gov
- MUD residents — see your tax statement
Cinco, Cross Creek, Firethorne, & Grand Lakes are served by Municipal Utility Districts. Your MUD name and operator phone are on your closing packet and your tax bill.

TRASH & RECYCLING

- Best Trash (most Cinco & Fulshear MUDs) **281-313-2378**
besttrashtexas.com
- Texas Pride Disposal (City of Katy + many MUDs) **281-342-8178**
texaspridedisposal.com
- City of Fulshear (residential GFL contract) **281-346-8830**
Service billed via City utility account.

INTERNET, CABLE & PHONE

- Xfinity (Comcast) **800-934-6489**
Cable & fiber. xfinity.com — check availability by address.
- AT&T **800-288-2020**
Fiber expanding rapidly across Katy & Fulshear. att.com
- Before you dig (Texas 811) **Dial 8-1-1**
Free locate of buried lines. Required by law before any digging. texas811.org

GOVERNMENT · DRIVER, VEHICLE, VOTER

- Texas DPS — Driver License
By appointment. dps.texas.gov · 90-day deadline for new Texans.
- Fort Bend County Tax Office (Katy branch) **281-341-3710**
22333 Grand Corner Dr. Vehicle reg., voter reg. fortbendcountytexas.gov
- Harris County Tax Office **713-274-8000**
Vehicle reg. & voter reg. for HC residents. hctax.net
- USPS **1-800-275-8777**
Mail forwarding online: usps.com/move

HOSPITALS · 24/7 EMERGENCY

- Houston Methodist West Hospital **832-522-1000**
18500 Katy Fwy. houstonmethodist.org/west
- Memorial Hermann Katy Hospital **281-644-7000**
23900 Katy Fwy. Level III trauma. memorialhermann.org/katy
- Texas Children's West Campus **832-227-1000**
18200 Katy Fwy. Pediatric ER. texaschildrens.org/west

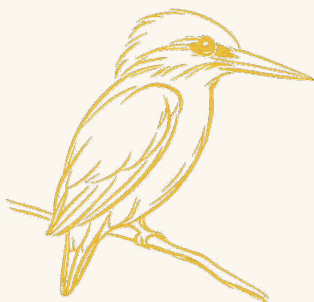
XVI

CHAPTER
The closing.

Coming Home

Are you ready to find home?

Relocating is a journey. Don't walk it alone. Whether you are months away from a move or a year past one and just need a steady hand for the next decision, Christa's door — like the screen door on every good front porch in Texas — is open.



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“Your advocate in Katy, Fulshear, and beyond.”

From the heart, it must come — or it will not come at all.

a saying Christa carried home from College Station





*Thank you for letting Christa
be a small part of your Texas chapter.*



WHY THE KINGFISHER



I chose the kingfisher because it captures how I see my role as your real estate partner: to guide you straight to the nest that truly feels like home. With its brilliant plumage, the kingfisher has long symbolized prosperity and good fortune — exactly what I want for every client. And like the kingfisher, I watch the market with patience and a sharp eye, ready to spot opportunities others miss and steer you clear of pitfalls. Whether you're buying, selling, relocating across the globe, or starting fresh down the street, the kingfisher is a reminder that with the right vision, timing, and courage, your next chapter can be a bright one. I'm here to help you dive confidently into something wonderful.

— Christa



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GROWN · GUIDED · GATHERED



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